Ashoka had, by this time, set down in stone all the measures that he had promulgated in that crucial twenty-sixth year. For some reason, in that same year, he also put out a kind of summarized account of his life and moral effort. Was this remembrance, where he mentions measures promulgated some fourteen years earlier, a sign that he was reaching the end of his days? We do know that this was close to the last time that he would speak in this way. Or perhaps being a preacher of sorts he knew the importance of repeating for effect the same idea in various forms.

The dominant impression remaining at the end of the pillar edicts is the unusually inclusive character of Ashoka's endeavour—the new directions, as well as the number of humans and other species sought to be uplifted by the new directions. The emperor's self-image as a *people's* monarch emerges movingly and powerfully. No emperor in the ancient world expresses such deep and abiding concern for the underprivileged, the dispossessed, the suffering, the oppressed, both human and animal. No other emperor of the ancient world is heard saying that his principal duty ought to mean visiting people personally.[48]

With one exception, on this note the pillar edicts end. The exception is the Seventh Edict added on the Topra pillar, now in Delhi. Why it appeared only at one place is unclear. It seems unlikely that the officers at Lauriya-Araraj, Kaushambi, and Meerut did not follow the emperor's instructions, or that the instructions were not communicated properly to them. This Seventh Edict is an amplification of the Sixth. Its importance stems from the fact that it is an overtly retrospective statement, the kind of testimony that could only have come from an ageing sovereign looking back on his life's work with pride and humility. They are the last words of the emperor to have survived.

In them Ashoka explores the distinction between him and past rulers. Earlier kings too had desired that 'men might (be made to) progress by the promotion of morality; but men were not made to progress by an adequate